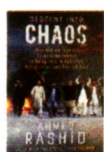


THE ROAD TO TERRORISTAN

Why war against Islamist terror is a lost cause as jihad becomes inseparable from Pakistan's national life



DESCENT INTO CHAOS

by AHMED RASHID

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■ By Brahma Chellaney

This book is more about Pakistan's tumble into chaos than about Afghanistan's continuing bedlam, despite its subtitle, "How the War Against Islamic Extremism is Being Lost in Pakistan, Afghanistan and Central Asia". Written in a reporter's narrative style, it recounts the events that have earned Pakistan disparaging labels like "Problemistan", "Terroristan" and "Al Qaidistan". Jihad culture is now deeply woven into its national fabric. Unravelling it won't be easy. But it is essential for regional and global security. Pakistan remains a common thread in the investigations into international terrorism. India has officially blamed "elements in Pakistan" for the bombing at its Kabul embassy.

The book is well-timed, with growing recognition among US analysts of the need for a broader focus on Pakistan and Afghanistan. The book, indeed, is a trenchant compendium of Bush administration's blunders that have undermined the global war on terror and helped fan Islamic extremism. Its author is well-known for a previous book on Taliban, published just before 9/11. Ahmed Rashid, one of Pakistan's most-respected journalists, has an unusual background: as a youth, he spent 10 years as a guerrilla fighter in Baluchistan. When the April-1978 Marxist coup occurred in Afghanistan, he was living in exile in Kabul. His mutinous credentials and Afghan links, subsequently, helped him as a

writer to gain access to the Taliban.

Rashid is unsparingly critical of the Bush administration's indulgent approach toward Pervez Musharraf. While the then secretary of state, Colin Powell, "had developed a close relationship with him", defence secretary Donald Rumsfeld was reluctant to "put pressure on Pakistan". According to Rashid, such lenience spilled over into Bush's second term, even as the Pakistan military and its powerful Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) agency aided and abetted Taliban and the Islamist groups in waging a terror campaign against India. The 2003-Iraq invasion only helped derail the war on terror. "Ultimately the strategies of the Bush administration have created a far bigger crisis in South and Central Asia than existed before 9/11," Rashid

imagined." Pakistan's success in meeting its central challenge—to move away from militarism and extremism, and toward a stable, moderate state—hinges on "the army and the ISI being pressured or persuaded to give up their twisted logic of insecurity, national pride and expansion in the region, (so as) to help sort out the country's problems, and to be good friends to Pakistan's neighbours, instead of constantly trying to undermine them. The army's insecurity, which since 1947 has essentially bred a covert policy of undermining neighbours, has now come full circle, for Pakistan's very future is at stake as extremists threaten to undermine Pakistan itself".

While such writings clearly do not sit well with the military establishment, with the author disclosing that

he was once summoned by Musharraf and warned to stop writing about ISI's continuing assistance to the Taliban, Rashid, at times, is unable to rise above Pakistani prejudices against India, alleging, for example, "the systematic use of rape as a weapon of terror by Indian soldiers" in Kashmir. He also equates Indian intelligence with the ISI in waging "a non-stop proxy war".

The book's main weakness, however, is that it is neither investigative nor scholarly but mainly a collation of recent events, up to Benazir Bhutto's assassination. The author narrates some events at length but other equally significant developments are ignored or under-reported. For instance, he dismisses Kargil War in one sentence but spends several pages on the IC-814 hijacking. But overall, the book is good and worth reading. It rightly argues that without elimination of Taliban sanctuaries in Pakistan, Afghanistan cannot be pacified. ■



FACE OF FEAR: A TV grab of terrorist training camps in Pakistani territory

writes. "There are more failing states in the Muslim world, while Al Qaeda has expanded around the world."

Hobbled by a domineering military, militant Islam, corruption and dependency on foreign aid, Pakistan remains a main breeding ground of global terror and the likely hideout of the most wanted terrorists, including Osama bin Laden. Yet, as Rashid says, "The Taliban are now expanding in Pakistan much faster than anyone could have